

*uplift mentorship program · summer 2026*

**Most people post the  
highlight reel. This is  
the retrospective.**

Unfiltered notes.

· *kennedy*

*first, some context*

## WHAT UPLIFT IS

Uplift pairs women and minority founders with experienced mentors for 10 weeks: one-on-one mentorship, practical workshops, and in-person events. **Free for founders, run by TechUnited.**

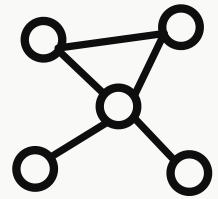
*and this summer?*

# The biggest Uplift program **ever.**

*five groups of  
founders at once  
8,000+  
mentorship  
minutes  
one summer*

How did a small team pull that off, and what did we learn? That's this document.

*how we ran it*



We treat community programs like products:

**You ship. You measure.**

**You listen. You improve.**

And every single improvement we shipped had the same goal:

**Increase the surface area  
for meaningful  
relationships.**

More chances for the right people to meet. More time for our team to be human with founders. The pages that follow are the six big things we tried, each with its so-what.

## WHAT WE DID

Uplift usually runs as one group of founders. This summer we ran five in parallel, each with its own sessions, events, and identity.

*so what?*

**Founders stopped  
identifying with their  
group and started  
identifying with Uplift.**

Ideas traveled between groups. Mentors met founders beyond the ones they were assigned. One community, five front doors. Would I do it again? Yes.

→ *more surface area for relationships.*



## WHAT WE DID

At our in-person events, we replaced awkward, open-ended icebreakers with stations that shepherd conversations:

**a thank-you card table** → set the tone for how we approach the room

**networking bingo** → practice asking people for things

**a 60-second pitch booth** → more founders seen, heard, and talked about

*so what?*

**People don't need networking events. They need permission to start conversations.**

Notice what didn't happen: "share a fun fact," "go meet more people." Every station gave people something to do together. We obsess over reducing friction in products and activations.

**A live community runs on the same fundamentals.**

→ *more surface area for relationships.*



## WHAT WE DID

In our one-on-one check-ins, founders told us directly: "we want more opportunities to engage with our peers." We were transparent back: we didn't have the bandwidth for more programming. So we proposed something simpler. What if we all just agreed to meet on Mondays? Would you come?

*they said yes. and it was awesome.*

*so what?*

**Big events create moments.**

**Small rituals create relationships.**

We all know this lesson. The connection hot spots surface around big events, but big events take effort and arrive rarely. Mondays cost almost nothing and come every week. Founders kept showing up. It's now permanent.

→ *more surface area for relationships.*

## WHAT WE DID

Every Uplift founder is paired with a mentor. This summer an algorithm proposed the pairings, based on industry, stage, and what each founder needed. Our team made every final call.

*so what?*

**The strongest mentor  
matches in program  
history.**

Many of those pairs plan to keep meeting after the program ends. That says everything.

→ *more surface area for relationships.*

## WHAT WE DID

We let AI handle the admin: attendance tracking, session summaries, progress reports, reminders. (Imperfectly. It broke sometimes.)

*so what?*

**Every hour not spent on  
admin became an hour  
with founders.**

That reclaimed bandwidth is what paid for Monday meetups and the extra in-person programming. AI didn't make the program less personal. It made it more personal.

→ *more surface area for relationships.*

## WHAT WE DID

We built each founder a simple portal: their sessions, their progress, and exactly what was left to finish the program.

*so what?*

**The team could finally see every founder's journey at a glance.**

"Who needs help this week?" went from guesswork to a glance. That changes how you support people.

→ *more surface area for relationships.*

*what it all adds up to*

# Capabilities outlive artifacts.

The portal is a tool. Knowing where every founder stands is a **capability**.

Tools get rebuilt. **What a program learns to do, it keeps.**

*the surprise we didn't plan*

## WHAT HAPPENED

As the summer went on, the ecosystem started showing up for our founders: Plug and Play, EqualSpace, Golden Seeds, investors, even the Mayor of Hoboken.

*so what?*

**One introduction leads to another. One person who shows up brings the next.**

**That's how an ecosystem compounds.**

None of it came from marketing. It came from people talking about the founders.



*→ more surface area for relationships.*

*now, the honest part*

*ouch.*

## WHAT BROKE

Not everything worked. Messages slipped through the cracks. Our home-built backend broke in places. And we focused on the founder experience more than the bigger home we were building: mentors deserve that same support, so the next version expands to include them.

*so what?*

**You can't improve  
systems that have never  
been tested.**

Running five groups at once stress-tested everything we had. Honestly? I'm grateful. Every rough edge is now a line on the next version's list.

*so, if we ran it again tomorrow...*

*v2 loading...*

☐ **A founder group chat**

the strongest communities are built between the programming, and founders need a place to keep helping each other

☐ **Programming for mentors**

they're a community of operators and investors too, and they deserve more than a thank-you

☐ **A dedicated developer**

the portal proved the concept; now build it into a real product

☐ **Partners across the whole journey**

investors and ecosystem orgs woven through the summer, beyond the big events

**Every cohort should leave a better playbook than the one before it.**

## *the takeaways · ten principles, part one*

### **1. Communities are architected.**

Every warm moment this summer traces back to a decision: who got matched, which station sat where, what happened on Mondays. Design the conditions and the connection follows.

### **2. Community scales through systems.**

A small team supported five groups because matching, tracking, and reporting ran on systems. The hours those systems saved went to people.

### **3. The best networking is designed.**

A thank-you table, bingo, a pitch booth. Each gave people something specific to do together, and the conversations started themselves.

### **4. Relationships compound across groups.**

Our strongest bonds crossed group lines. Every founder, mentor, and partner added raises the odds that the right two people meet.

### **5. Automation should buy back human time.**

Every hour AI saved on admin went into a one-on-one, a Monday meetup, or an in-person event. That's the test for adding any of it.

## *the takeaways · part two*

### **6. Small rituals beat big events.**

Coffee on Mondays did more for relationships than any stage moment. Frequency builds trust; spectacle builds memories.

### **7. Operational friction is feedback.**

Five groups at once stress-tested every process we had. Where it hurt is exactly where the next version gets better.

### **8. Attrition is data.**

Founders rarely left because the content failed them. They left where scheduling and follow-through collided, so those are the systems we fix.

### **9. Pilots prove concepts. Products deserve real builds.**

Our duct-taped portal proved that founders and staff need one. The next step is a dedicated developer and a real build.

### **10. Leave the playbook better than you found it.**

The matches, the Mondays, the bugs: all of it is written down, so the next cohort starts ahead of where we did.

Off to build the next version. **Thank you** to everyone who showed up.

· *kennedy*

